assistance, particularly air assistance, because of wider implications...in the global context and we did not want to embarrass our friends. The situation that has developed is, however, desperate. We have to have more comprehensive assistance if the Chinese are to be prevented from taking over the whole of Eastern India. Any delay in this assistance reaching us will result in nothing short of a catastrophe for our country'.

India's request for comprehensive aid, especially 'immediate support to strengthen our air arm sufficiently to stem the tide of the Chinese advance' goes into minute detail, and is prefaced by the statement: 'We have repeatedly felt the need to use our air arm in support of our land forces but have been unable to do so because in the present state...we have no defence against retaliatory action by the Chinese.' In this context his specific demands were for: '[A] minimum of 12 squadrons of supersonic all-weather fighters' and 'modern radar cover [which] we don't have'. The draft further added that USAF personnel 'will have to man these fighters and radar installations while our personnel are being trained'. Among other things, Nehru was pleading for twelve squadrons of Lockheed F-104 Starfighters and two squadrons of Canberra B-57 bombers.

Both Palit and Lall asked Sarin why the air chief, Air Marshal Aspy Engineer, was not being consulted. Sarin said that apart from him, the foreign secretary and the prime minister, no one else knew of the letter. These two officers were clearly not qualified to answer the question and at best could make only an educated guess. They both agreed that since the Pakistan Air Force had inducted the F-104 and the B-57 and operated these aircraft from airfields that were similar to ours, they could justifiably be asked for.

So shocking were the contents of the letter that the Indian ambassador to the US, B. K. Nehru, contemplated holding it back and not passing it on to the White House at the time. Later, the Government of India denied the existence of these two letters and another communication sent a month earlier by Nehru to Kennedy. In 1965, the then Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri categorically denied that the letters existed in either the Prime Minister's Secretariat or the External Affairs Ministry. However, many years later when the JFK Library declassified the letters, Inder Malhotra, one of India's most respected journalists, accessed them.

The third big blunder was that despite his conversation with Thorat, Thapar's suggestion for evacuating Assam was weighing heavily on the